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I Forgot How to Rest.

For the woman who can't switch off — when
sleep stopped working and stopping feels wrong.

This isn't tired. This is burnout — and rest stopped working.

You sleep eight hours and wake up exhausted. You finally sit down and feel guilty, twitchy, wrong — so you grab your phone, because doing nothing feels like failing. Somewhere along the way, "busy" became your identity, and rest became a thing you'd earn once everything was handled. Which is never.

Here's the part that matters: a bubble bath won't fix this, because this isn't a tiredness problem — it's a **nervous-system** problem. You've been in fight-or-flight for so long your body forgot how to come down. That's why scrolling, wine, and "relaxing" leave you emptier. You're not resting — you're numbing a system that's stuck in the on position. This guide is about switching it off — for real, at the wiring level — and unhooking your worth from your output.

THE DISTINCTION THAT CHANGES IT

Numbing quiets the noise but leaves you drained. Rest down-regulates your nervous system and actually refills you. Most of what you call "relaxing" is numbing. We're going to swap it for the real thing.

STEP 1

The burnout check

Tick what's been true lately. This isn't a personality — it's depletion, and depletion is reversible.

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| ☐ Tired even after a full night's sleep | ☐ Can't relax without guilt or restlessness |
| ☐ Dreading things I used to enjoy | ☐ Getting sick more often |
| ☐ Snapping at people I love | ☐ Nothing feels fun anymore |
| ☐ Foggy — can't focus or decide | ☐ Resentful of everything I "have" to do |
| ☐ Numb, just going through the motions | ☐ Running on caffeine and sugar |
| ☐ Cynical or detached | ☐ Fantasizing about everything just stopping |

WHAT THIS ACTUALLY IS

Several of these isn't a bad week — it's a body that's been redlining too long. You can't think your way out of burnout, and you can't push through it. You can only let the system come down. That's a skill, and you can relearn it.

STEP 2

Why you literally can't rest

Resting feels impossible for real reasons. Name yours — then call it the lie it is:

- **"If I stop, everything falls apart."** It won't — it'll just be imperfect. And burnout makes you worse at all of it anyway.
- **"I'll rest when everything's done."** It is never done. That's the trap that runs you into the ground.
- **"Resting is lazy / selfish."** Whose voice is that? You absorbed it somewhere. It isn't true and it isn't yours to keep.
- **"Being busy is who I am."** You existed before the to-do list. Your worth was never your output — that's the wound under the burnout.

THE ROOT

Burnout is rarely just overwork — it's overwork plus the belief that you're only valuable when you're producing. Heal the belief and rest stops feeling like a threat.

STEP 3

Nervous-system resets (not bubble baths)

These actually down-regulate a fried nervous system. No vacation required — do one today:

- 1 The long exhale.** Breathe in 4, out 8 — the long exhale is the one switch that tells your body "the threat is over." Two minutes drops you out of fight-or-flight faster than anything else.

- 2 Cold on the face.** Splash cold water on your face or hold something cold to your cheeks for 30 seconds. It physically triggers the calming (vagal) response. Instant down-shift.

- 3 The 5-minute nothing.** Sit. No phone, no task, no podcast. Stare out a window and let your brain be bored. Bored is the doorway to rest — numbing slams it shut.

- 4 Sensory quiet.** Burnout is often sensory overload. Kill one input — lights down, noise off, screen away — for 10 minutes. Less in equals more capacity.

- 5 Co-regulate.** Ten minutes with a calm person, a pet, or in nature. Your nervous system settles by borrowing calm from a calm thing. Isolation keeps it revved.

STEP 4

Restore vs. numb

Not all "downtime" refills you. Some just sedates the exhaustion and leaves you emptier. Know the difference and trade up:

ACTUALLY RESTORES

Sleep. A walk outside. Real talk with someone. Sunlight. Moving your body. Making something. Quiet. A real meal + water. Doing nothing on purpose.

JUST NUMBS

Doom-scrolling. Bingeing to avoid. Wine to "switch off." Online shopping. Saying yes to fill silence. More caffeine. Busywork disguised as rest.

THE IDENTITY PIECE

Practice resting *before* the work is done — on purpose. Every time you do, you teach your body the truth: you are allowed to exist without producing. That's the deepest rest there is.

Rest is productive. Stopping is a skill.

Read these slowly — they reprogram the wound under the burnout:

- I don't have to be useful to be worthy. That was settled before I did a single thing.
- Rest is maintenance, not a reward I earn.
- The world keeps spinning while I sit down.
- An empty woman has nothing left to give anyway.
- Slowing down now is how I avoid breaking down later.

DO ONE NOW

Before you close this: breathe in for 4, out for 8, five times. That's not nothing — that's your nervous system stepping down. You just rested. Do it again in an hour.

You're allowed to stop before you break.

A long exhale. Cold water. Five minutes of real nothing. Rest that fills you instead of numbing you. You didn't forget how to rest because you're broken — your body got stuck in the on position, and now you have the switch. Use it today, before the crash makes you.

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